

PRESS RELEASE

“Saving Lives Under Threat: Thousands in Central Mali Protected from Explosive Risks Amid Funding Crisis”

Bamako, July 14, 2026

While the number of displaced people in Mali is growing and funding is dwindling, DanChurchAid (DCA) Mali and its national partner, AAPPOR, continue to deliver support to tens of thousands of the most vulnerable among them with the support of the European Union. Almost 55,000 Malians have received lifesaving training on identifying and deal with unexploded bombs – and now the same people are training others in their communities.

Mali has been impacted by the devolving security context in the Sahel for more than a decade – with grave human costs. Thousands of civilians have been displaced in search of safety away from their communities and the impact of the insecurity across the Sahel has also resulted in large number of refugees seeking safety in Mali. Mali is currently home to more than 138,000 refugees – predominantly from Burkina Faso and Niger.

They are joined by a growing number of Malians who are displaced by fighting in their own country. According to the Malian government there were 378,363 internally displaced people (IDPs) in Mali in September 2024, and 414,524 in December 2025 due to worsening insecurity. And this number continues to rise.

People who are displaced lack almost everything – and are at great risk of harm. They need support and protection – two things that DCA and its Malian partner AAPPOR (Association pour l’Appui aux Populations Rurales) have been delivering with EU humanitarian support. For children, men and women in rural communities affected by conflict in Mali, unexploded bombs pose a grave risk when they move into areas unfamiliar to them.

And while the needs are on the rise, the world – and Mali – are affected by a decline in funding for humanitarian assistance. In recent years this has impacted the ability of humanitarian organisations, including DCA, to provide critical aid to the most vulnerable populations. According to the UN’s office for Humanitarian Affairs, OCHA, only 16% of the \$577.9 million funding plan to help 5.1 million people in need of assistance in Mali in 2026 had been secured by May. This is the lowest percentage in the last decade, despite the worsening situation in the country.

In this context, DCA and AAPPOR are completing the first 24 months phase of a project aimed to alleviate the suffering of vulnerable populations affected by the ongoing conflict in the districts of Macina, Niono, San et Tominian, in central Mali. Funded by the European Union the project educates communities about the risks of unexploded bombs and ammunition as well as guns and small arms in the communities, and offers assistance to victims of these devices.

Since its launch in April 2024, the project has reached 54,820 individuals - more than half being women and girls - with training (explosive ordnance risk education), as well as small arms and light weapons awareness raising. This is 20% more than projected when work began in 2024.

The project has strengthened local protection mechanisms through the training of 36 community focal points and 80 volunteers and provided logistical, medical, food, cash and psychosocial assistance to 406 victims of explosive ordnance and small arms-related incidents. This is slightly above the target made possible by the strong engagement from the community and the combined collaboration of focal points and volunteers trained by the project.

Equitable innovative approaches such as inclusive training of people with disabilities and the use of radio and sketches have further contributed to enhancing sensitisation and dissemination of life-saving information in hard-to-access areas and with marginalised populations.

Joanna OLSEN, Country Director for DCA in Mali, says “We are working with our partners to support communities so they can continue to protect themselves and their families. We have seen that communities continue awareness raising activities even after the official activities are completed. They understand that this information saves lives.”

Esmée DE JONG, Head of EU Humanitarian Aid Operations in Mali, says "Long after the fighting moves on, explosive ordnance continues to kill and injure civilians. For families in Mali, knowing how to recognise and avoid these deadly hazards can mean the difference between life and death. The European Union is helping communities to protect themselves and ensuring explosive ordnance survivors receive the support they need."

About DCA in Mali:

DCA has been operating in Mali for over a decade implementing emergency and development interventions across the country.

DCA's operations in Mali span three main sectors:

1. Humanitarian Mine Action (HMA) to enhance safety and national capacity through explosive ordnance risk education, mental health and psychosocial support, and victim assistance;

2. Food security and livelihoods, including climate change adaptation, resilient agropastoral practices, group cash transfers, and sustainable natural resource management;
3. Conflict prevention and peacebuilding, through the promotion of inclusive dialogue and inter/intracommunity collaboration, supporting equitable access to resources, community action planning, inclusive-decision making process and participatory local conflict resolution mechanisms.

DCA also strives to mainstream gender and conflict sensitivity across all its activities, supporting women-led initiatives and challenging restrictive gender norms.

About EU Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid:

The European Union and its Member States are the world's leading donor of humanitarian aid.

Relief assistance is an expression of European solidarity with people in need all around the world. It aims to save lives, prevent and alleviate human suffering, and safeguard the integrity and human dignity of populations affected by natural disasters and man-made crises.

Through its Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid Operations department, the European Union helps millions of victims of conflict and disasters every year. With headquarters in Brussels and a global network of field offices, the EU provides assistance to the most vulnerable people on the basis of humanitarian needs.

Photos:

Available upon request.

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